

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

MISSING THE BEAT

The Navratri Pujo celebrations are not going well for West Bengal CM **Mamata Banerjee**. On October 5, her dandiya dance at a pujo pandal inauguration quickly became viral meme fodder. Social media was flooded with messages comparing her to fickle emperor Nero who 'fiddled as Rome burned', for the same day a minor girl had been raped and murdered in Joynagar in South 24 Parganas. Mamata was criticised for "prancing around while women faced violence in her state". And this was no isolated case. The previous day, a sexual abuse case of a 16-year-old in Jatragachi in New Town, Kolkata, had come to light. Already under fire in the RG Kar Medical College rape-murder case, the perceived indifference has people all riled up despite her call for "capital punishment" in the Joynagar case.

Navratri Notes

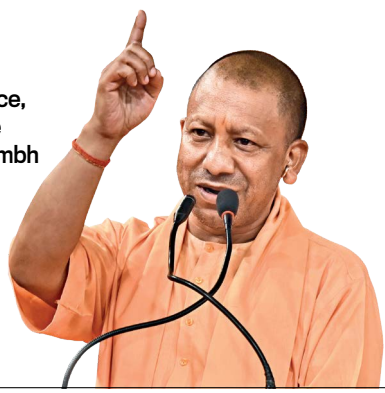
Prime Minister **Narendra Modi** continues his tradition of penning garba songs for Navratri. This year, it's a ditty called '*Aavti Kalay*', a tribute to Goddess Durga, which has been shared on the PM's social media handle. Sung by singer Purva Mantri in the popular Dakla folk style, it's become a hit with the faithful. Last year, PM Modi had shared '*Gaay Eno Garbo*', celebrating the pride of Gujarat's folk dance. Prominent singers like Devang Patel have rendered Modi's garba compositions, some of which are featured in his book, *Aankh Aa Dhanya Chhe* (whose English title is *Letters to Self*).



ANI

AKHARA AFFAIR

After Uttar Pradesh CM **Yogi Adityanath** took office, Allahabad had been renamed Prayagraj before the hugely successful 2019 Kumbh Mela. The 2025 Mahakumbh will see more changes with Yogi accepting a request from the akharas to replace Urdu-Persian terms with Sanskritised alternatives. So the holy dip 'shahi snan' will now be called 'rajsi snan', while the 'peshwai' (procession of akharas) becomes 'chhavani pravesh'. For Yogi, it's a win-win, the move appeases the sants and boosts his Hindutva cred ahead of the Mahakumbh.



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

MANN MUZZLED



Punjab CM **Bhagwant Mann** faced a significant 'power cut' as soon as his Aam Aadmi Party chief Arvind Kejriwal secured bail. Two close aides, Onkar Singh and Navneet Wadhwa, were abruptly removed, as were four ministers. Onkar, a personal friend of Mann, managed his Dhuri constituency and wife Gurpreet Kaur's political activities, while Wadhwa handled the CM's communications. The Delhi leadership has also pushed to cut Gurpreet's security to avoid a "political backlash".

Fund Flows

Ahead of the 2024 Lok Sabha election, the Congress had claimed a cash crunch but has now reported that it spent Rs 585 crore on the polls and four state elections. This is, of course, much less than the Rs 821 crore spent in 2019.



The party allocated Rs 410 crore to ads, Rs 46 crore to virtual campaigns, and Rs 105 crore on air travel for its top leaders including Mallikarjun Kharge, **Rahul Gandhi** and Priyanka Gandhi Vadra. Despite earlier concerns over frozen bank accounts, the Congress received Rs 539.4 crore in receipts, with Rs 170 crore already in hand. It seems, in politics, money always finds its way.

Kaushik Deka with Arkamoy Datta Majumdar, Jumana Shah, Ashish Misra and Anilesh S. Mahajan